

certification for Positive Luxury by meeting sustainability's highest standards," says Sahni.

For Forest Essentials, the challenge was making Ayurveda feel aspirational, says Executive Director Samrath Bedi. Founded in 2000, the team deduced a workable solution; "to maintain the highest standards while investing in packaging, design, and communication that speak the language of global luxury," Bedi says, "Consumers recognise we spend 18 months to two years on a product. That rigour, combined with our farm-to-bottle authenticity, places us on a par with international peers."

That both succeeded in their quests is testified by the interest they elicited from global beauty giants. Spanish conglomerate Puig acquired a majority stake in Kama Ayurveda in 2019 and Estée Lauder Companies bought a minority stake in Forest Essentials in 2008.

68 | A fail-safe brand will pique inter-generational curiosity. While Ayurveda has, for long, commanded the attention of Gen X and millennials alike, attracting a younger demographic can be difficult. Bedi feels Gen Z has fundamentally reshaped luxury, "They demand authenticity, purpose, and transparency. Gen Z resonates with a deeper sense of personalisation and knowledge, and values sustainability and clean formulations."

T **HERE IS A BELIEF** in fashion circles that it is only India's diaspora that advocates for homegrown designers. Malhotra stresses that people respond to great craft when they see one. "When we showcased at the Harrods Private Shopping Penthouse in London (2024), I saw firsthand how curious clients were—they wanted to hear the story behind each piece. And it's not just Indians abroad, everyone is recognising the beauty of handwork."

CRAFT DESERVES CREDIT

▼ Prada's 'toe-ring sandals' resemble Kolhapuri chappals

► The global design fraternity has relentlessly drawn inspiration from communities it has romanticised through literature and history. However, the line between appreciation and appropriation is crossed when the receiver plunders cultural pasts to satiate creative visions without crediting the source. While a few brands have expressed regret in the past—Rodarte (2012), when accused of insensitivity towards Australian aboriginal culture, licensed the artwork and shared proceeds with the respective party, and Marc Jacobs (2017) responded with an apology when models donned dreadlocks—others like Gucci (2018) refused to issue apologies.

The recent row over Prada's 2026 men's collection featuring a version of Kolhapuris, the traditional handcrafted leather sandals that has received a GI-tag covering artisans from Maharashtra and Karnataka, is yet another case of appropriation. After social media outcry, the brand acknowledged the sandal's origin and met Kolhapuri artisans, later hinting at a collaboration. However, such borrowing is detrimental to commerce for the artisans. Rahul Mishra points out that India is "a mix of America's innovation, France's craftsmanship, and China's scale. What is missing is protecting our IPs." Malhotra says the way forward is "through respectful collaboration. You have to give credit to the craft and the people behind it, and honour the communities that keep it alive."

